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PRC Strategic Culture, Ideology, and Decision Architecture

Historical Foundations, Governing Logic, Threat Perception, and Implications for U.S. Enforcement Design

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Analytical Posture Statement

This paper analyzes the strategic culture, governing ideology, and institutional decision architecture of the People's Republic of China. It is designed to inform enforcement design by modeling how PRC decision-makers perceive threats, process information, and respond to external pressure — not to characterize Chinese civilization, culture, or people as adversarial. The author's direct personal and professional experience in China informs the analysis throughout. The distinction between state conduct and civilizational character is a governing constraint on this document.

Bottom Line Up Front

The PRC's strategic behavior is best understood as the output of an institutional system in which Marxist-Leninist party organization, civilizational self-conception, and historical humiliation narratives interact to shape threat perception, policy adaptation, and regime legitimation. The available evidence is most consistent with a mixed assessment: PRC conduct appears defensive in some domains — particularly those linked to sovereignty and territorial integrity — primarily revisionist in others — particularly international order and institutional primacy — and increasingly filtered through a framework of national rejuvenation, security, and external constraint. This paper designates this the Hypothesis C assessment and assigns it MODERATE CONFIDENCE.

The available evidence supports the assessment that the CCP employs historical memory as an active legitimating and mobilizational instrument, that Xi Jinping has shifted the party's legitimacy basis from economic performance toward security and national rejuvenation, and that U.S. enforcement instruments appear to face an adversary adaptation cycle in which political framing, self-reliance policy, and institutional substitution can erode coercive effectiveness over time. The critical policy-relevant finding is that the PRC processes sanctions and export controls simultaneously as practical constraints and as politically useful evidence of external encirclement — in some cases reinforcing the self-reliance narratives and substitution incentives those instruments are intended to constrain. Enforcement design informed by this analysis should calibrate intensity and targeting by issue domain: sovereignty-linked enforcement will encounter maximum resistance; order-linked enforcement will face strategic adaptation; commercial enforcement is amenable to conventional cost-benefit incentives.

PART 1 — HISTORICAL FOUNDATIONS

1.1 The Century of Humiliation operates in CCP discourse as a recurring instrument of legitimation

The period from 1839 to 1949 is not merely historical memory in the PRC — it is a recurring instrument of legitimation, threat framing, and political mobilization in CCP discourse, deployed by every CCP leader since Mao to justify policy, mobilize domestic support, and frame external adversaries. The evidence for this assessment is robust across PRC primary sources and Western scholarship.

PRC leadership invocations. Mao Zedong established the foundational frame on September 21, 1949, in his address to the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference: "Ours will no longer be a nation subject to insult and humiliation. We have stood up."[1] Xi Jinping has made this narrative a central legitimating frame of his public political discourse. At his first public appearance as General Secretary in November 2012, Xi visited the "Road toward Renewal" exhibition at the National Museum and declared national rejuvenation "the greatest dream for the Chinese nation in modern history."[2] At the CPC centenary on July 1, 2021, Xi stated that after the Opium War of 1840, China was gradually reduced to a semi-colonial, semi-feudal society, enduring intense humiliation and civilizational decline.[3] At the 70th anniversary of victory over Japan in September 2015, Xi declared that China had put an end to its century of national humiliation (paraphrased; official translation: "put an end to China's national humiliation of suffering successive defeats").[4] At the NPC in March 2023, he stated the CPC had worked "for a century to put an end to China's national humiliation."[5]

Jiang Zemin operationalized this narrative institutionally, launching the Patriotic Education Campaign in 1991. Hu Jintao drew on adjacent concepts, proposing a "harmonious world" rooted in Confucian language that implicitly contrasted Chinese civilizational depth with Western "youth."

The scholarly framework. Zheng Wang's *Never Forget National Humiliation* (Columbia UP, 2012)[6] — winner of the ISA Yale H. Ferguson Award — provides the most rigorous analysis. Wang's central thesis is that the CCP has bolstered post-Tiananmen legitimacy by using historical memory as an active political instrument to cultivate a nationalistic, anti-Western victim identity. He cites William Callahan's argument that the discourse of the century of humiliation functions as the "master narrative" of modern Chinese history. The CCP follows an ideological reeducation program that consistently portrays China as a victim of foreign imperialist pressure. Wang employs Johan Galtung's "Chosenness-Myth-Trauma" (CMT) analytical framework, demonstrating that the CCP engages in selective remembering and forgetting — glorifying Ming admiral Zheng He's voyages as peaceful while overlooking military aggression against neighbors.

The Patriotic Education Campaign. Launched in August 1991 under Jiang Zemin[8] — directly triggered by Tiananmen and the Soviet collapse — this campaign constituted systematic ideological reeducation. Suisheng Zhao's foundational 1998 paper in *Communist and Post-Communist Studies*[7] characterized it as a state-led nationalist movement that redefined the legitimacy of the post-Tiananmen leadership in a way that would permit Communist Party rule to

continue on the basis of non-Communist ideology. By 1995, 100 national-level "patriotic education demonstration bases" were designated, nearly two-thirds dedicated to past wars. Over 2,300 provincial and county-level sites were created across just five provinces.

Analytical assessment. The Century of Humiliation functions not merely as historical memory but as a recurring instrument of legitimation, threat framing, and political mobilization in CCP discourse. It provides legitimation (only the CCP ended the humiliation), threat construction (foreign powers will humiliate China again without vigilance), and policy mobilization (sanctions and export controls can be framed in official discourse as contemporary forms of external constraint, a pattern with implications for later adaptation and narrative mobilization). This last function has direct enforcement design implications addressed in Part 6.

Evidentiary note: Direct PRC primary sources (Xi speeches via Xinhua, CPC centenary address, NPC transcripts) constitute Tier 1 evidence. Wang's scholarly work is Tier 3, corroborated by Zhao's 1998 paper. The gap: internal CCP deliberations on how deliberately this narrative is calibrated remain classified or inaccessible.

1.2 Civilizational self-concept serves dual political functions

The CCP's deployment of Chinese civilizational identity operates on two registers simultaneously: civilizational confidence (5,000 years of continuous greatness) and modern victimhood (the aberrational century of foreign domination). This tension is best understood as a politically useful synthesis in CCP discourse: the party presents itself simultaneously as custodian of a long civilizational inheritance and as the force that reversed a modern period of national humiliation.

The 5,000-year claim as political instrument. Xi Jinping has made this claim foundational. In a May 2022 Politburo collective study session on the origins of Chinese civilization, Xi stated that archaeological projects have confirmed China possesses "a million-year human history, 10,000 years of cultural history, and more than 5,000 years of civilizational history." He told Donald Trump in 2017 that while Egyptian civilization arose earlier, "the only continuous civilization to continue onwards is China's."[12] In official discourse, the 5,000-year civilizational claim appears to serve several political functions: it positions the CCP as guardian of cultural continuity, casts the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries as aberrational decline rather than historical norm, and supports a narrative that Chinese political development should not be judged solely against Western liberal standards.

Tianxia and the Chinese world order. The tianxia (天下, "all under heaven") concept represents the pre-Westphalian Chinese understanding of world order — not multiple sovereign states but a single, hierarchically ordered world centered on the Chinese central plains. Kissinger captures the distinction:[13] whereas Western international law developed around sovereign equality, China never encountered societies of comparable culture or magnitude. Zhao Tingyang's *Tianxia Tixi* (2005; English edition UC Press, 2021)[10] revived this concept for modern audiences. The CCP has instrumentalized tianxia-adjacent concepts through Xi's "community of shared future for mankind" and the Global Civilization Initiative (March 2023). This does not mean contemporary PRC decision-making is a direct continuation of premodern tianxia practice; rather, it suggests that selected historical concepts remain available for modern political reinterpretation.

Confucian governance instrumentalization. The CCP's relationship to Confucianism has undergone a complete reversal. Under Mao, Confucius was vilified as a feudal leftover — Red Guards destroyed relics at Qufu during the Cultural Revolution. Post-reform rehabilitation was gradual, accelerating under Xi. Xi made a pilgrimage to Qufu in 2013 and quotes Confucian thinkers frequently. In Xi-era political messaging, the CCP increasingly presents itself as the authorized custodian of traditional Chinese culture, narrowing the rhetorical space between loyalty to party rule and loyalty to national tradition. The mandate of heaven concept has been repackaged in Marxist language, but the underlying idea — that those who gain popular support gain state power — persists.

Key academic sources. Alastair Iain Johnston's *Cultural Realism* (Princeton UP, 1995)[9] challenges the "peaceful China" myth. Johnston argues that Chinese strategic texts contain both accommodationist and hard realpolitik strands, and that the latter is more analytically salient in his reading of the Ming material. This argument should be used with caution. Johnston's analysis is influential, but his Ming-dynasty case selection may bias the result toward conflictual strategic behavior, and later imperial practice does not map neatly onto the same paradigm. The paper should therefore use Johnston as one interpretive lens rather than as dispositive proof of a transhistorical Chinese strategic culture.

Yan Xuetong (*Ancient Chinese Thought, Modern Chinese Power*, Princeton UP, 2011) provides a competing framework, arguing pre-Qin philosophy offers usable grand strategy concepts — distinguishing humane authority, hegemony, and tyranny. Kissinger's *On China* (2011) introduces the wei qi versus chess contrast and develops the concept of shi (势) — strategic potential energy. Kissinger's formulations are useful heuristics for contrasting strategic traditions, but they are better treated as interpretive metaphors than as stand-alone evidence of current PRC decision logic.

Analytical assessment. The CCP's use of civilizational language appears to broaden its legitimating repertoire beyond Marxist-Leninist ideology alone, especially under Xi. Johnston's work warns against taking China's self-characterization of peaceful strategic culture at face value, though his finding applies most strongly to the historical case he examined.

1.3 The CCP's dual character as Leninist party and nationalist movement

The CCP is simultaneously a Marxist-Leninist party and a Chinese nationalist movement; in practice, the party has often fused these identities rather than treating them as fully distinct. Rush Doshi's formulation is precise:[25] the CCP is a nationalist party that emerged from the patriotic ferment of the late Qing period, and a Leninist party that has built centralized institutions to govern the country and achieve its nationalist mission. The party's nationalist orientation sets the ends of Chinese grand strategy, while Leninism provides an instrument for realizing them. Doshi's formulation is analytically useful here because it distinguishes nationalist objective from Leninist instrument, though the extent of coherence across time and policy domains remains an assessed rather than fully demonstrable proposition.

The Yan'an template. The Yan'an Rectification Movement (1942–1944) established the template for CCP ideological discipline that persists today. It consolidated Mao's paramount role, established Mao Zedong Thought as party doctrine, and created the methodology of thought reform: study sessions, self-criticism, struggle sessions, and forced confessions. Kenneth

Lieberthal assessed that the legacies of this movement proved fundamental to subsequent CCP history, achieving an unprecedented level of unity. Xi has explicitly revived this model through his 2013–2017 campaigns (mass line, "two studies one action," "three stricts three honests") and the 2020–2021 political-legal rectification campaign.

Legacy structures that persist. Tony Saich's *From Rebel to Ruler* (Harvard UP, 2021)[22] documents how the CCP evolved into a market-oriented yet essentially Leninist political behemoth that fluctuates between soft and hard authoritarianism. Despite 100 years of existence and over 70 years of rule, the party has not fully institutionalized its ruling apparatus — a deficit most apparent with respect to succession.

The CCP as instrument of national salvation. The party's foundational narrative frames it as the savior of the Chinese nation. Xi's 2021 centenary speech emphasized that the Party and Chinese people have achieved the transformation from standing up and growing prosperous to becoming strong. In official party framing, challenges to CCP rule are frequently presented not as ordinary political disagreement but as threats to national unity, stability, or rejuvenation.

PART 2 — GOVERNING IDEOLOGY AND INSTITUTIONAL STRUCTURE

2.1 The CCP legitimacy model rests primarily on performance rather than electoral procedure

The CCP justifies its monopoly on power through performance legitimacy — delivering economic growth and national dignity in exchange for political control. This performance-based bargain has been a major component of regime durability since Tiananmen, alongside coercive capacity, nationalism, and institutional adaptation.

The post-Tiananmen compact. After the Tiananmen Square crackdown, Deng Xiaoping and the CCP concluded that a form of informal social contract with the people was urgently needed: the government would open up the economy while the people would agree not to challenge the authority of the state.

Why collapse predictions failed. Andrew Nathan's seminal 2003[14] *Journal of Democracy* article, "Authoritarian Resilience," provided the analytical framework. Nathan identified four institutional features that explained CCP durability: increasingly norm-bound succession politics, meritocratic promotion, functional specialization, and input institutions that channeled grievances individually. His conclusion: authoritarianism may be a viable regime form even under conditions of advanced modernization.

Gordon Chang's *The Coming Collapse of China* (2001) predicted near-term regime collapse. David Shambaugh's March 2015 WSJ piece "The Coming Chinese Crackup" was more consequential. Both analyses appear, in retrospect, to have underestimated CCP institutional resilience, adaptive capacity, and the extent to which regime durability could be maintained without liberal political convergence.

Xi's renegotiation of the contract. Under Xi, the legitimacy balance appears to be shifting from growth-first performance toward a broader mix of security, rejuvenation, distributional control, and political discipline. In a Qiushi-published speech (August 2021), Xi stated that realizing common prosperity is more than an economic goal — it is a major political issue bearing on the Party's governance foundation. The ODNI 2025 ATA captures the risk: China's leaders probably are most concerned about corruption, demographic imbalances, and fiscal and economic struggles[21] because they threaten economic performance and quality of life, two key factors underpinning CCP legitimacy.

2.2 Xi Jinping Thought represents a structural shift toward personalist rule

Xi Jinping has consolidated power to a degree widely assessed as the most pronounced since Mao, reversing important elements of the post-Deng effort to routinize elite politics. This shift likely affects both the information environment surrounding top-level decision-making and the regime's tolerance for policy distortion caused by loyalty-centric politics.

The great rejuvenation as organizing principle. At the 19th Party Congress (October 2017), Xi declared China closer than any time in history to realizing the great rejuvenation. At the 20th

Party Congress (October 2022), he stated the rejuvenation is on an irreversible historical course. The Two Centenary Goals provide the timeline: the first was declared achieved in July 2021; the second targets 2049.

Ideological consolidation. Xi Jinping Thought on Socialism with Chinese Characteristics for a New Era was enshrined in the party constitution at the 19th Congress — a status previously reserved for Mao Zedong Thought and Deng Xiaoping Theory.

Power consolidation. On March 11, 2018, the NPC voted 2,958 to 2[17] to remove presidential term limits. At the 20th Party Congress, Xi secured an unprecedented third term and populated the Politburo Standing Committee entirely with loyalists. Susan Shirk's assessment in the *Journal of Democracy*: Xi Jinping is taking China back to personalistic dictatorship after decades of institutionalized collective leadership — a reversion suggesting that the change from personalism to institutionalized collective leadership in authoritarian regimes is cyclical, not evolutionary. Elizabeth Economy's *The Third Revolution*[19] documents the centralization of power under Xi, the expansion of the Communist Party's role, and the construction of a virtual wall to control the exchange of ideas and capital.

Loyalty-centric centralization may degrade decision quality. Xi's consolidation has increased analyst concern that personal loyalty is being prioritized over corrective feedback, with possible effects on policy quality and internal candor. The ODNI 2025 ATA directly addresses this: Xi's emphasis on security and loyalty may be degrading the regime's capacity to address complex domestic challenges.[21] Illustrative indicators include the abrupt zero-COVID reversal, opaque elite personnel removals (Qin Gang, Li Shangfu), and policy uncertainty in a weaker economic environment, though these developments do not by themselves prove a generalized failure of decision-making.

Institutional variation. While CCP strategy reflects centralized direction, implementation is mediated by bureaucratic incentives, institutional fragmentation, and information constraints that can produce variation in execution. Effects on decision quality likely vary across policy domains and depend on the extent to which feedback mechanisms remain intact within specific bureaucratic channels. This variation means the PRC should not be modeled as a fully coherent strategic actor; partial coherence with bureaucratic friction is the more accurate characterization.

2.3 The party-state-military architecture is organized around party supremacy

Understanding PRC institutional architecture requires a critical distinction that Western analysis frequently blurs: the party is not the state, the state is not the military, the military is not the civilization, and none of these are the Chinese people.

Party over state. All important government positions are held by CCP members, and party leadership positions take precedence. Under Xi, many analysts assess that the State Council's relative policy autonomy has narrowed as authority has been pulled into party commissions, leading groups, and Xi-chaired coordinating bodies. Total CCP membership: approximately 99 million (7% of the population).

PLA as party army. The Central Military Commission is first and foremost a party organization, meaning China's military reports to the CCP, not the Chinese state (ChinaPower/CSIS). Political

commissars at regiment-level and above are officially equal to military commanders in status. Non-CCP parties are prohibited from organizing within the PLA. The DoD China Military Power Report 2024 confirms the PLA's political work system has been central since its founding as the party army of the CCP.

United Front Work Department. The UFWD operates directly under the CCP Central Committee, headed by a Politburo member. Xi called the united front a "magic weapon," echoing Mao. Under Xi, approximately 40,000 total staff were added[24]. External research, including ASPI's work, characterizes the united front system as an institutional mechanism for influence, cooptation, and network penetration across diaspora, academic, civic, and commercial settings; however, specific effects vary by case and should be attributed carefully.

Civil-military fusion as institutional doctrine. In January 2017, Xi created the Central Military-Civil Fusion Development Committee, which he personally chairs. The DoD characterizes CMF as part of an effort highlighting and countering the PRC's strategy to support PLA modernization by ensuring its access to advanced technologies acquired and developed by entities that appear civilian. At least 36 national-level MCF industrial zones have been designated.

2.4 Information control shapes the domestic operating environment

The PRC's information control architecture extends beyond censorship alone and helps structure the domestic information environment in which political events, foreign actors, and collective action are understood.

The Great Firewall as ecosystem. The Great Firewall reflects China's concept of "internet sovereignty." By blocking major foreign platforms, the GFW simultaneously controls information flows and creates a protected domestic market for Baidu, WeChat, Weibo, and Douyin. The system employs IP blocking, DNS poisoning, keyword filtering, Deep Packet Inspection, and TCP reset attacks.

What censorship actually targets. Gary King, Jennifer Pan, and Margaret Roberts[83] (Harvard, 2013 *American Political Science Review*, based on 11 million Chinese social media posts) produced a counterintuitive finding: posts with negative criticism of the state are not more likely to be censored. Instead, the censorship program targets collective action by silencing comments that represent or spur social mobilization, regardless of content. Their summary: the Chinese people are individually free but collectively in chains. Their 2014 *Science* study confirmed that posts with collective-action potential were censored regardless of whether they supported or opposed government policy.

Propaganda effects on U.S. perception. Available survey and media-analysis evidence suggests that official framing can materially affect public attitudes toward the United States, though those effects are not total and do not eliminate variation in private opinion. A 2022 Tsinghua University survey[86] found that approximately 80% of Chinese respondents blamed the United States and Western countries for Russia's war in Ukraine — a finding consistent with the official narrative promoted through state media and inconsistent with independent international reporting, suggesting effective framing rather than independent public judgment. A 2024 PNAS study found a marked decline in Chinese attitudes toward the United States between 2019 and 2022.

The gap between narrative and private opinion. Stanford research by Jennifer Pan and Yiqing Xu (analyzed by CSIS) reveals important nuance. Their findings suggest that politically liberal and less nationalistic preferences are more common among wealthier and more educated respondents than official nationalist discourse might imply.

PART 3 — PRC STRATEGIC CULTURE AND DECISION LOGIC

3.1 PRC official discourse often presents the current international order as historically contingent and open to revision

PRC strategic discourse frequently portrays U.S.-led unipolarity as historically contingent rather than permanent, while presenting multipolarity as both an emerging trend and a more legitimate organizing principle.

The grand strategy framework. Rush Doshi offers an influential interpretation in which PRC strategy evolves through sequential phases of blunting, building, and expansion; this framework is analytically useful, though it should be treated as an interpretive model rather than uncontested official doctrine. The blunting phase (1989–2008) followed the "Traumatic Trifecta" — Tiananmen, the Gulf War, and Soviet collapse. The building phase (2008–2016) was triggered by the global financial crisis. The expansion phase (2016–present) followed perceived Western fractures; CCP leaders began invoking "great changes unseen in a century,"[30] reflecting a recurring official assessment that relative shifts in global power are creating opportunities for China.

Comprehensive national power. The DoD CMPR 2024 provides the authoritative characterization: for Beijing, comprehensive national power represents a country's overall measure of power actualized across multiple domains — economic, technological, diplomatic, political, cultural, and military.

Multipolarity as strategy. PRC MFA statements are explicit. Wang Yi at Munich (February 2025):[27] "A multipolar world is not only a historical inevitability; it is also becoming a reality."

Evidentiary note. This subsection establishes the discursive framework; the strongest behavioral evidence of order-revision activity — economic coercion, institutional substitution, and parallel financial architecture — appears in Part 4. The relatively thin primary-source base here reflects the gap between declaratory posture (abundant) and observable strategic action (documented later).

3.2 PRC official discourse increasingly presents the United States as the principal external constraint on national rejuvenation

ODNI, DoD, and PRC official statements broadly converge on this point, though they differ in framing, attribution, and implied policy meaning.

USG assessment of PRC perception. The ODNI 2025 ATA states that Beijing is deeply suspicious of U.S. intentions and views Washington's measures against China as part of a concerted, whole-of-government effort to contain China's development and rise, undermine CCP rule, and prevent the PRC from achieving its aims. The ODNI 2026 ATA sharpens this: Beijing has long viewed the U.S. as pursuing a coordinated effort to contain China's development and rise. The DoD CMPR 2024 cites Xi directly: western countries led by the United States have implemented all-round containment, encirclement and suppression.

"Containment" as default interpretive frame. In official PRC framing, U.S. actions are frequently interpreted through a containment lens, regardless of whether U.S. policymakers describe those actions as deterrent, defensive, competitive, or conduct-based. This is a critical finding for enforcement design: actions intended as targeted conduct-based enforcement may be received as civilizational containment.

U.S. decline assessment. The PRC's formulation "great changes unseen in a century," first used by Xi in December 2017, encodes a programmatic assessment of declining Western and rising Chinese power. However, Chinese views are not monolithic — the ODNI 2026 ATA notes the PRC also sees benefits to and is prioritizing a productive, stable economic relationship with the U.S.

3.3 PRC risk calculus combines strategic patience with sovereignty-driven loss aversion

PRC leaders generally appear strategic, patient, and sensitive to costs, but their decision-making operates within a framework in which sovereignty, territorial integrity, and regime legitimacy can alter ordinary cost-benefit calculations.

What rational actor models get right. The ODNI 2025 ATA characterizes the PRC as more cautious than Russia, Iran, and North Korea about risking its economic and diplomatic image. Both the 2025 and 2026 ATAs note that China's leaders will seek opportunities to reduce tension with Washington when they believe it benefits Beijing.

What they get wrong. M. Taylor Fravel's *Strong Borders, Secure Nation* (2008)[31] produces the critical counterintuitive finding: China is more likely to use force when it perceives its own bargaining position declining — not from a position of strength. Conversely, in 17 of 23 territorial disputes through 2005, Beijing offered some form of concession. Post-2005 behavior — including South China Sea island-building, the Doklam standoff (2017), and the Galwan Valley clash (2020) — suggests the accommodationist pattern may be less operative under Xi, though the sample remains too small for confident assessment. This pattern suggests that declining bargaining leverage and sovereignty-linked loss aversion may be more useful explanatory variables than simple expansionist preference alone.

Taiwan as a core regime-legitimacy issue. Xi has tied reunification explicitly to national rejuvenation and party legitimacy. The PRC 2019 Defense White Paper states[32] China will never allow the secession of any part of its territory. The ODNI 2026 ATA provides important calibration:[29,33] the 2025 ATA assessed that Chinese leaders do not currently plan to execute an invasion of Taiwan in 2027; the 2026 ATA reframes the assessment, stating that "China will likely seek to set the conditions for an eventual peaceful reunification with Taiwan, short of conflict."

Sanctions through the Century of Humiliation frame. For enforcement analysis, the key implication is that sanctions and export controls may operate simultaneously as material constraints and as politically useful evidence of external encirclement. Xi compared China's need for domestic technology independence to the significance of the "Two Bombs, One Satellite" program (CSIS). The concept of zìlì gēngshēng (self-reliance) operates not merely as economic policy but as a narrative of national endurance through constraint.

3.4 Adversary adaptation can erode enforcement effectiveness over time

The available evidence suggests that some U.S. enforcement instruments lose coercive effectiveness over time as PRC institutions adapt through substitution, workarounds, industrial policy, and narrative mobilization. The PRC semiconductor case provides the clearest empirical record.

SMIC's advance under export restrictions. SMIC was added to the Entity List in December 2020[34], when its most advanced known process was 14nm. Gregory Allen (CSIS) established that SMIC was producing 7nm chips no later than July 2022[35] using DUV multi-patterning lithography without any EUV machines. The August 2023 Huawei Mate 60 Pro revelation was widely perceived as a deliberate political signal. By December 2025, TechInsights confirmed SMIC was producing chips on its N+3 process — characterized by TechInsights as a "scaled evolution" of its 7nm-class technology with meaningful density improvements that nonetheless "remains substantially less scaled than leading commercial 5nm nodes." Industry analysis suggests advanced DUV multi-patterning techniques, potentially including self-aligned quadruple patterning, enable this progress. Available industry and policy analysis suggests that China remains materially behind global leaders at the frontier, but the lag has narrowed in at least some commercially and strategically relevant areas despite tightened controls.

Evidence consistent with diminishing marginal coercive returns. CSIS analysis (April 2025)[88] finds that export controls are relevant only so long as the U.S. and allies possess chip technologies China needs, and that Chinese firms do not necessarily require access to the most advanced Western technologies to achieve comparable competencies. Prior to export controls, Chinese-made semiconductor manufacturing equipment held 10–15% of China's domestic market; post-controls, domestic firms now supply 40% of the etching and thin-film deposition market.

Dual circulation as institutionalized adaptation. Xi announced the dual circulation strategy in May 2020[38]. The critical passage: China must tighten international production chains' dependence on China, forming powerful countermeasures against foreigners artificially cutting off supplies.

State investment scale. The Big Fund has deployed capital across three phases totaling approximately $96 billion, using exchange rates at the time each phase was established. Phase III alone ($47.5B, May 2024) exceeds the $39B in direct incentives from the U.S. CHIPS and Science Act.

Note on "coercive window" language. Throughout this paper, "coercive window" is used as analytical shorthand for the period over which an enforcement tool loses a substantial portion of its coercive advantage because of substitution, adaptation, or allied leakage; it is not presented as a precise econometric measure.

PART 4 — What the PRC Is Doing to the United States

The behaviors documented below are not a threat inventory. Each entry answers a single question: what does this conduct reveal about CCP institutional logic, threat perception, or decision architecture? The pattern that emerges is a party-state in which technology acquisition, infrastructure pre-positioning, military modernization, economic leverage, and transnational control are frequently linked through a shared framework of national rejuvenation, security, and state-directed capability building, rather than treated as wholly separate policy domains.

4.1 The intelligence apparatus reveals how the party-state acquires technology

The cases presented here suggest that important PRC intelligence operations against the United States are not merely opportunistic, but are embedded in a broader institutional architecture linking state security, technology acquisition, and national development objectives.

Scale of operations. FBI Director Christopher Wray stated at the Hudson Institute on July 7, 2020, that the Bureau was opening a new China-related counterintelligence case about every 10 hours and that of the nearly 5,000 active FBI counterintelligence cases, almost half were related to China. By January 31, 2022, at the Reagan Presidential Library, Wray reported over 2,000 open cases.

The institutional logic Wray identified is critical to this paper's framework. He articulated the structural problem: many of the distinctions Americans take for granted are blurred, if they exist at all, in the PRC context — distinctions between the Chinese government and the CCP, between civilian and military sectors, between the state and the business sector. This is not best understood as a series of isolated bad actors exploiting gaps in the system; it is more plausibly read as evidence that the institutional boundaries Western systems treat as distinct are narrower, weaker, or differently structured in the PRC context.

State-directed espionage operations. The conviction of Yanjun Xu — Deputy Division Director of the Jiangsu Bureau of the MSS — provides the clearest window. Xu was arrested in Belgium in April 2018, becoming the first Chinese intelligence officer ever extradited to the United States. He was convicted in November 2021 on all counts of economic espionage targeting GE Aviation's composite aircraft engine fan module and sentenced to 20 years[41]. His defense team's characterization is analytically significant: Xu was working to further his country's interests, not as a rogue operator. The case strongly supports the assessment that technology acquisition of this kind can operate as an authorized function within MSS-directed activity rather than as rogue or purely entrepreneurial conduct.

The APT40 indictment (July 19, 2021[42]) revealed the operational infrastructure: three MSS officers and a contract hacker operated through Hainan Xiandun Technology Development Co., a front company staffed with university-recruited hackers. One officer received an MSS performance award. This is evidence of a bureaucratized and incentivized acquisition system, rather than activity that can be explained solely as freelance or unsupervised conduct.

On June 27, 2025, DOJ arrested Yuance Chen and Liren "Ryan" Lai[87] for acting as agents of the PRC government, facilitating dead-drop payments for the MSS and attempting to recruit U.S. Navy personnel.

Thousand Talents as institutional practice. The prosecution of Dr. Charles Lieber, former chair of Harvard's Chemistry Department, illustrates how talent recruitment programs function as systematic technology transfer mechanisms. Lieber was convicted on December 21, 2021, on six counts related to concealing participation in China's Thousand Talents Plan. Wuhan University of Technology paid him up to $50,000 per month, living expenses of up to $150,000, and more than $1.5 million to conduct joint research at Wuhan University of Technology — while his Harvard group received over $15 million in federal grants from DOD and NIH. The FBI characterizes Thousand Talents as a talent recruitment plan designed to attract high-level scientific talent in furtherance of China's scientific development, economic prosperity and national security. The program's explicit linking of economic prosperity and national security reflects the CCP's refusal to maintain the Western distinction between commercial and strategic domains.

In a separate case, Song Guo Zheng[44], an Ohio State University professor, was sentenced to 37 months in federal prison on May 14, 2021, after admitting he used approximately $4.1 million in NIH grants to develop China's expertise in rheumatology while concealing affiliations with at least five Chinese research institutions.

Overseas police stations. Safeguard Defenders' September 2022 report identified 54 Chinese overseas police service stations in 30 countries[45]. A December 2022 follow-up expanded the count to at least 102 stations in 53 countries. DOJ's first arrests came April 17, 2023 (Lu Jianwang and Chen Jinping[46], operating an undeclared station in Manhattan). On December 18, 2024, Chen pleaded guilty, stating: "I knowingly acted as a foreign agent."

The distinction that matters. The FBI's own guidance draws the line through transparency: participation in talent plans is not inherently illegal — concealment of affiliations, one-directional transfer, and state direction are what cross the line. This distinction is essential to Part 5's analysis of where enforcement overreached. These cases do not generalize to Chinese nationals, diaspora communities, or academic collaboration broadly. The relevant distinction is between lawful participation and concealed, state-directed activity. Failure to maintain this distinction undermines both the credibility and the effectiveness of enforcement, as the China Initiative experience documented in Section 5.2 demonstrates.

Aggregate cost. Independent estimates of annual IP theft costs range widely, from $225 billion to $600 billion (IP Commission, 2017[47]), reflecting methodological disagreement about what constitutes measurable loss. The ODNI estimated in 2015 that economic espionage through hacking alone costs $400 billion per year[48]. These figures are order-of-magnitude estimates; their value is directional rather than precise, and they should be read accordingly. Even conservative estimates indicate losses on a scale that constitutes a structural economic threat.

4.2 Cyber operations are consistent with contingency preparation tied to Taiwan-related deterrence and disruption

Available U.S. official reporting supports the assessment that PRC cyber activity against U.S. critical infrastructure has, in at least some cases, moved beyond traditional espionage toward pre-positioning that could support disruptive operations in a crisis or conflict.

Volt Typhoon: pre-positioning in critical infrastructure. The CISA/NSA/FBI joint advisory AA24-038A (February 7, 2024)[49] assessed with high confidence that Volt Typhoon actors are pre-positioning on IT networks to enable lateral movement to OT assets to disrupt functions across communications, energy, transportation, and water sectors — including facilities in Guam. The advisory stated that Volt Typhoon's choice of targets and pattern of behavior is not consistent with traditional cyber espionage. The actors had maintained access to some networks for at least five years.

FBI Director Wray testified before the House Select Committee on January 31, 2024: China's hackers are positioning on American infrastructure in activity consistent with preparation that could enable disruptive operations if or when China decides the time has come to strike. On the PRC cyber program's scale, Wray stated: the PRC has a bigger hacking program than every other major nation combined, and if every FBI cyber agent focused exclusively on China, PRC hackers would still outnumber them at least 50 to 1[50].

CISA Director Jen Easterly testified at the same hearing that the Chinese government believes it will likely crush American will for the U.S. to defend Taiwan through infrastructure disruption. National Cyber Director Harry Coker's written testimony tied Volt Typhoon directly to PLA doctrine: pre-positioning for disruptive or destructive operations, in line with the People's Liberation Army's doctrinal approach to cyberspace.

Salt Typhoon: compromising the surveillance architecture. The FBI and CISA confirmed on November 13, 2024, that PRC-affiliated actors compromised networks at multiple telecommunications companies — ultimately nine confirmed, including AT&T[51], Verizon, T-Mobile, and Lumen Technologies — to steal call records data, compromise private communications of individuals in government or political activity, and copy information subject to lawful intercept orders under CALEA. Senator Mark Warner characterized it as potentially one of the biggest breaches ever.

Flax Typhoon: botnet infrastructure. On September 18, 2024, FBI Director Wray announced disruption of a botnet comprising over 260,000 compromised devices controlled by Integrity Technology Group, a Beijing-based company publicly traded on the Shanghai stock exchange. OFAC sanctions followed on January 3, 2025.

What the cyber pattern suggests. Taken together, the three campaigns are consistent with a multi-layered operational approach that could improve PRC capacity to deter, disrupt, or degrade U.S. response in a Taiwan-related crisis. This pattern is more consistent with long-horizon preparation than with opportunistic exploitation alone. It can be read, cautiously, as compatible with the broader PRC preference for shaping favorable conditions before decisive confrontation, though that interpretive bridge should be treated as analytic synthesis rather than direct proof of doctrinal intent.

4.3 Military modernization is embedded in the CCP's ideological and legitimacy framework

This section is deliberately brief. Its purpose is not to replicate the DoD CMPR but to establish that PLA modernization is not merely a military-technical project; it is also embedded in the CCP's ideological and legitimacy framework of national rejuvenation.

The 2024 CMPR (December 18, 2024)[26] frames this explicitly: the PRC's national strategy is to achieve the great rejuvenation of the Chinese nation by 2049, and the concept is broad enough to justify almost any policy put forth by the CCP.

The three-step timeline plus 2027. Xi established milestones at the 19th Party Congress: mechanization by 2020, modernization by 2035, and a "world-class military" by 2049. The 2027 "Centennial Military Building Goal" marks the PLA's 100th anniversary. The CMPR 2024 assessed that the PLA made uneven progress toward this milestone.

Nuclear expansion trajectory. The CMPR series documents acceleration: from "low 200s" warheads (2020 estimate) to surpassing 600 operational warheads (CMPR 2024 estimate as of mid-2024)[53] to a projection of over 1,000 by 2030 (CMPR 2024 projection). Three new silo fields totaling 320 silos have been completed. The PRC is developing an early warning counterstrike capability.

Anti-access/area denial. The DF-21D, DF-26 "Guam Killer" (~4,000 km range, ~250 launchers), and new DF-27 (5,000–8,000 km range) form the backbone of what the PRC calls "counter-intervention." The CMPR 2024 revealed the DF-27's anti-ship variant, potentially extending conventional strike capability to unprecedented range.

The ideological connection. The PLA's modernization drive is closely linked to a party-state legitimacy narrative centered on returning China to great-power status by 2049, even though military modernization also reflects conventional security competition, contingency planning, and bureaucratic momentum. Within this framework, Taiwan is treated not merely as a territorial issue but as a core political and ideological question bound up with rejuvenation, sovereignty, and party legitimacy.

4.4 Economic coercion reveals the party-state model in practice

The CCP frequently treats economic relationships as instruments of state power rather than as fully autonomous commercial domains. This is an institutional feature of the party-state model. The evidence comes from strategic infrastructure acquisition abroad and punitive economic campaigns against states that cross CCP-defined red lines.

Belt and Road as strategic infrastructure. The Hambantota Port case is frequently cited but more nuanced than "debt-trap diplomacy" allows. China Eximbank issued approximately $1.1–1.4 billion in loans. When Sri Lanka faced a balance-of-payments crisis, China Merchants Port Holdings acquired an 85% stake under a 99-year concession[54] for $1.12 billion — a lease fee, not debt cancellation. The institutional significance is less that Beijing can be shown to design "debt traps" in every case, and more that the party-state's lending architecture can create structural vulnerability in borrower countries in ways that may later serve strategic interests. AidData's 2023 "Belt and Road Reboot" report found that 60% of Beijing's overseas lending now

supports borrowers in financial distress, up from less than 5% in 2010. COSCO's acquisition of 67% of Greece's Piraeus Port Authority followed a similar trajectory.

United Front Work Department operations. ASPI's June 2020 report documented the UFWD as coordinating influence across foreign political parties, diaspora communities, and corporations. DOJ cases have documented UFWD-connected operations on U.S. soil, including the May 2023 Boston case and Operation Fox Hunt charges.

Economic coercion case studies. Four cases demonstrate the institutional pattern:

Australia (2020–2024). After PM Morrison called for a COVID-19 origins inquiry, China imposed 80.5% tariffs on barley, 116–218% tariffs on wine, and restricted approximately 12 industries — an estimated A$6.6 billion (approximately US$4.9 billion) in lost export revenue. Iron ore — essential to China's steel industry — was never touched, revealing strategic calculation.

South Korea (2017). After THAAD deployment, Lotte Group saw 74 of 112 Chinese stores shut down, Chinese tourist arrivals dropped nearly 50%, and total estimated losses reached $7.5 billion. Resolution required South Korea's "Three Noes" commitments.

Lithuania (2021–2022). After opening a "Taiwanese Representative Office," China removed Lithuania from its customs system. Imports dropped approximately 91% by December 2021 and over 99% by January 2022[57]. Secondary pressure affected approximately 60 companies and blocked ~1,200 containers worth ~$260 million. The EU fast-tracked its Anti-Coercion Instrument partly in response.

Norway (2010–2016). After the Nobel Committee awarded Liu Xiaobo the Peace Prize, China froze diplomatic relations for six years. Norwegian salmon market share dropped from 92% to 29%. Resolution required Norway to pledge not to "support actions that undermine" China's core interests.

The institutional pattern. In these cases, China generally avoided formal acknowledgment that economic sanctions were being imposed, suggesting a preference for informal coercion that preserves deniability while maximizing pressure. Target selection follows consistent logic: small democratic countries, politically sensitive industries, but never sectors critical to Chinese supply chains. Party-state governance mechanisms — party cells in firms, the cadre management system, the 2017 National Intelligence Law — compel economic actors to serve state objectives, repeatedly narrowing or overriding the boundary between commercial and strategic activity (Atlantic Council, November 2023).

4.5 Fentanyl precursors, forced labor, transnational repression, and IP theft at scale

The preceding sections document intelligence, cyber, military, and economic coercion. This section addresses four additional domains of PRC conduct that harm Americans directly and reveal the same institutional logic: a party-state that can control its domestic actors when it chooses to, and whose enforcement gaps on export-facing illicit activity are therefore best understood as reflecting priorities rather than incapacity.

Fentanyl precursor supply. The ODNI 2025 ATA identifies China as "the primary source country for illicit fentanyl precursor chemicals and pill pressing equipment." In 2022, more than

107,000 Americans died from drug overdoses, with approximately 70% involving fentanyl; preliminary CDC data for 2023 indicate a decline to approximately 105,000 (CDC/DEA). For Americans aged 18–45, fentanyl overdose is the leading cause of death. The PRC scheduled all fentanyl-related substances as a class in May 2019, after which direct shipments of finished fentanyl to the U.S. declined substantially (2025 INCSR). However, China-based chemical suppliers — operating on the extensively surveilled Chinese internet — pivoted to manufacturing and exporting precursor chemicals to Mexican cartels, often accompanied by synthesis instructions. The House Select Committee on the CCP (April 2024) found that "PRC companies openly selling these illicit materials on the extensively surveilled Chinese internet" were left untouched by enforcement authorities — while the CCP aggressively censored domestic drug sale content. The 2025 INCSR assessed that the PRC's enforcement of its counternarcotics regulations remains "uneven and opaque." This gap between rhetorical cooperation and actual enforcement is analytically significant: it suggests that the party-state's information control apparatus, documented in Section 2.4, is capable of suppressing illicit commercial activity when the CCP prioritizes doing so, and that the persistence of precursor export activity reflects an enforcement choice rather than an enforcement failure.

Following the November 2023 Biden-Xi San Francisco summit, the PRC took incremental enforcement steps — scheduling three fentanyl precursors in August 2024, cooperating on a money laundering arrest, and placing export controls on 13 precursor chemicals to North America in November 2025. In June 2025, the PRC completed scheduling all fentanyl precursors scheduled by the INCB.[89] These steps, while meaningful, occurred only under sustained diplomatic pressure and remain, in the State Department's assessment, insufficient.

Forced labor and ethnic assimilation. The Uyghur Forced Labor Prevention Act (UFLPA), signed December 23, 2021[61], creates a rebuttable presumption that goods produced in the Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region are made with forced labor and are therefore prohibited from U.S. import. The ideological connection is direct: ethnic assimilation in Xinjiang is driven by the same national unity imperative that drives the Taiwan reunification narrative — the CCP treats separatism in any form as an existential threat to the party-state. The Newlines Institute[64] for Strategy and Policy, in partnership with the Raoul Wallenberg Centre for Human Rights, published an independent legal analysis (March 2021) concluding that the PRC bears state responsibility for an ongoing genocide against the Uyghurs in breach of the 1948 Genocide Convention. ASPI's 2020 report "Uyghurs for Sale" documented approximately 80,000 Uyghur[62] transfers to factories across China between 2017 and 2019 under conditions that strongly suggest forced labor. The Xinjiang Police Files, published May 2022 by an international media consortium[63] (corroborating evidence), included internal security directives, surveillance photographs, and detainee records.

Transnational repression at scale. Freedom House's transnational repression database records 1,219 incidents of direct, physical transnational repression by 48 governments between 2014 and 2024. The Chinese government remains the most prolific perpetrator, committing 272 incidents of transnational repression (across physical, digital, and institutional categories)[58] — 22% of recorded cases — across assassination, rendition, assault, spyware, family intimidation, digital threats, Interpol abuse, and mobility controls. Freedom House assesses that China conducts "the most sophisticated, global, and comprehensive campaign of transnational repression in the world." This extends beyond the overseas police stations documented in Section 4.1 to include Operation Fox Hunt coerced returns (PRC police claimed 230,000

individuals "persuaded" to return between 2021 and 2022), surveillance of diaspora communities, threats against family members remaining in China, and digital harassment of activists, journalists, and members of ethnic and religious minorities including Uyghurs, Tibetans, and Falun Gong practitioners. The ideological connection is information control (Part 2.4) extending beyond borders: the CCP's domestic apparatus for monitoring, censoring, and mobilizing is deployed extraterritorially against populations the party defines as threats regardless of where they reside.

IP theft aggregate cost. As noted in Section 4.1, independent estimates of annual IP theft costs range from $225 billion to $600 billion (IP Commission) and $400 billion in cyber-enabled espionage alone (ODNI, 2015). These are order-of-magnitude estimates whose value is directional rather than precise (see methodological note, Section 4.1). These figures, combined with the documented cases of state-directed espionage (MSS operations), talent plan exploitation (Thousand Talents), and cyber-enabled theft (APT40 and related campaigns), establish that the aggregate scale of PRC-directed and PRC-linked intellectual property acquisition constitutes a structural economic and national security challenge — not an isolated enforcement problem.

4.6 Influence and perception-shaping activities

The preceding sections document physical, cyber, economic, and military dimensions of PRC conduct toward the United States. This section addresses a distinct domain: activities that may shape the informational and perceptual environment in which U.S. policy decisions are made. These activities are not best understood as traditional military psychological operations but as components of a broader political influence architecture that extends the domestic information control apparatus (Section 2.4) beyond PRC borders.

Domestic foundation. The CCP's domestic information control system — documented in Section 2.4 — establishes the institutional base from which external influence activities operate. The party maintains narrative discipline across state media, controls the domestic internet through the Great Firewall, and targets collective action rather than individual criticism (King, Pan, and Roberts, 2013).[83] The Tsinghua survey finding[86] that approximately 80% of Chinese respondents attributed blame for Russia's war in Ukraine to the United States and Western countries is consistent with effective domestic narrative framing on foreign policy issues. This domestic apparatus provides both the institutional infrastructure and the operational personnel for external influence activities.

External influence mechanisms. The United Front Work Department[84] operates as the CCP's primary institutional vehicle for external influence, with approximately 40,000 total staff[24] coordinating activities across foreign political parties, diaspora communities, academic institutions, and commercial entities. Observable mechanisms include: media acquisition and content agreements (CGTN, China Daily inserts in Western newspapers); Confucius Institute operational constraints on host institutions; pressure on diaspora organizations and overseas Chinese community associations; and selective engagement with foreign political figures, business leaders, and cultural organizations. DOJ cases have documented UFWD-connected operations on U.S. soil.[46] The analytical difficulty is distinguishing centrally directed influence from activities that emerge from institutional incentives within the party-state or from autonomous dynamics that happen to align with CCP messaging.

Cyber-enabled informational positioning. The cyber pre-positioning documented in Section 4.2 — particularly Salt Typhoon's compromise of telecommunications infrastructure[51] — creates potential informational leverage beyond its primary intelligence function. Access to communications metadata, call records, and lawfully intercepted communications could, under certain conditions, support targeted influence operations, although available evidence does not establish that this access has been used for that purpose. The distinction between intelligence collection and influence enablement is analytically important but may be operationally blurred in practice.

Analytical assessment (LOW CONFIDENCE). Available evidence supports the assessment that the PRC operates a multi-layered influence system — domestic information control, UFWD external engagement, media acquisition, and diaspora-facing institutional pressure — with measurable effects in some audience segments. The Tsinghua survey data[86] demonstrates effective domestic narrative framing on foreign policy issues. UFWD operational cases documented by DOJ[46] establish that influence infrastructure extends to U.S. soil. Media acquisition and Confucius Institute content constraints create observable channels for narrative shaping. These activities collectively constitute an influence architecture that can affect foreign perception environments, including in the United States. LOW CONFIDENCE is assigned because: (a) the scale of measurable effect on U.S. audiences specifically cannot be isolated from organic domestic dynamics; (b) the degree of central coordination versus distributed institutional behavior varies by channel; and (c) attribution of specific perceptual outcomes to PRC-linked activity remains methodologically challenging. This assessment is directional, not precise — it identifies a capability with documented institutional backing, not a measured outcome.

Prominent vectors and measurable outcomes. The most visible PRC-origin information platform in the United States is TikTok (ByteDance), with over 170 million American users. The Protecting Americans from Foreign Adversary Controlled Applications Act (PAFACA, April 2024) reflects legislative concern about algorithmic influence and data access, though the national security case remains contested and the platform's operational independence from CCP direction is disputed. Separately, academic self-censorship in China studies — documented by Sheena Greitens ("Scholar, Surveilled," 2020), Jessica Chen Weiss, and AAS survey data[92] — represents a measurable influence outcome achieved without overt coercion: researchers preemptively avoid topics (Taiwan, Xinjiang, Hong Kong) that could jeopardize fieldwork access or institutional relationships. The conceptual framework most useful for analyzing these activities is Walker and Ludwig's "sharp power" distinction[91] between authoritarian influence (manipulative, exploiting the openness of democratic institutions) and democratic soft power (attractive, earned through transparency). The PRC activities documented in this section fit the sharp-power model: they operate through the manipulation of informational and institutional environments rather than through the attraction of PRC governance values.

Evidentiary note. This subsection relies primarily on Tier 2 and Tier 3 sources. Direct evidence of centrally coordinated influence campaigns targeting U.S. domestic audiences is limited in open sources. The most robust evidence concerns media acquisition, Confucius Institute operational constraints, documented UFWD-connected operations, and transnational repression against diaspora communities.[58] Attribution of specific perceptual effects to PRC-linked activity — as distinct from organic dynamics within U.S. domestic politics — remains methodologically challenging.

4.7 Why the PRC does these things — behavior connected to institutional logic

The behaviors documented in Sections 4.1 through 4.5 should not be read as civilizational aggression. They are more plausibly understood as recurrent outputs of CCP institutional imperatives operating within a party-state decision framework.

At minimum, CCP regime durability appears to depend heavily on three linked priorities. First, preventing Taiwan independence — which the CCP has defined as essential to rejuvenation, making it an ideological imperative. Second, maintaining economic growth sufficient to sustain the performance legitimacy model. Third, achieving technological self-sufficiency to reduce vulnerability to external leverage.

These priorities help explain the behaviors observed, even if they do not exhaust every causal factor behind them. Intelligence operations targeting technology reflect a system that treats technology acquisition as a national security function. Cyber pre-positioning reflects PLA doctrinal preparation for a Taiwan contingency. Military modernization is embedded in the rejuvenation legitimacy narrative. Economic coercion reflects a governance architecture that repeatedly narrows or overrides the boundary between commercial and strategic activity. Fentanyl precursor enforcement gaps reflect a regime that can control its chemical industry when it chooses to but has not consistently prioritized doing so when the harm falls on foreign populations. Forced labor in Xinjiang and transnational repression against diaspora communities reflect the same national unity imperative that drives the Taiwan question.

These behaviors conflict directly with U.S. interests. The United States has legitimate interests in protecting critical infrastructure, maintaining technological advantage, preserving freedom of navigation in the Western Pacific, defending allies against coercion, and protecting its citizens from the consequences of illicit drug flows. That conflict is the basis for enforcement — not civilizational hostility, racial animus, or the assumption that Chinese culture is inherently aggressive. The threat arises from a specific governance model operated by a specific political party. Precision about the source of the threat is analytically necessary and morally required.

The preceding sections establish that the PRC challenge is documented, institutional, and warrants enforcement. What follows assesses where the U.S. enforcement response has been disproportionate or counterproductive, because imprecise enforcement degrades both civil liberties and strategic effectiveness. Part 5 is not a concession to balance; it is an operational critique. Enforcement that substitutes breadth for precision imposes costs on Americans, accelerates adversary adaptation, and undermines the conduct-based distinction that separates effective policy from discriminatory overreach.

PART 5 — Where U.S. Policy Has Been Wrong

5.1 The engagement consensus misread CCP institutional resilience

For three decades, U.S. policy toward China rested on a bipartisan assumption: economic integration would produce political liberalization. This assumption proved wrong, and the institutional analysis developed in Part 2 helps explain why it was more vulnerable than many policymakers recognized at the time.

The assumption articulated. President Clinton, speaking at Johns Hopkins SAIS on March 8, 2000[65], made the case for China's WTO accession: "By joining the WTO, China is not simply agreeing to import more of our products; it is agreeing to import one of democracy's most cherished values, economic freedom." He predicted the internet would overwhelm CCP control. The Bush administration continued this trajectory — the 2002 National Security Strategy[66] predicted that "in time, China will find that social and political freedom is the only source of that greatness." Deputy Secretary of State Zoellick's September 2005[67] "responsible stakeholder" speech called on China to be integrated into rather than fenced out of the international system.

What engagement produced. The measurable consequences of engagement were uneven: it accelerated trade, growth, and integration, but also facilitated forms of dependency, leverage, and technology transfer that U.S. policymakers increasingly came to view as strategic liabilities. China's GDP rose from $1.34 trillion at WTO accession[68] to $17.79 trillion by 2023. The U.S. goods trade deficit with China peaked at approximately $418 billion in 2018[69]. The Economic Policy Institute estimated the deficit cost 3.4 million U.S. jobs between 2001 and 2017. Political liberalization did not occur. Xi abolished presidential term limits in 2018 and Document No. 9 (2013) explicitly identified Western constitutional democracy as a threat to regime survival.

A widely influential reassessment came from Kurt Campbell and Ely Ratner in *Foreign Affairs* (February 2018): "Nearly half a century since Nixon's first steps toward rapprochement, the record is increasingly clear that Washington once again put too much faith in its power to shape China's trajectory." They assessed that on economics, rather than becoming a force for greater openness, consistent growth has served to legitimize the Communist Party and its state-led economic model. Both subsequently served as senior officials implementing the replacement policy — Campbell as Deputy Secretary of State (confirmed February 2024), Ratner as Assistant Secretary of Defense for Indo-Pacific Security Affairs.

Why engagement underperformed against its own assumptions. The engagement consensus rested on modernization theory — the assumption that economic development inevitably produces democratic governance. Nathan's "Authoritarian Resilience" documented why the CCP proved more durable than this theory predicted. The CCP adapted to markets without liberalizing in part because deeper political opening was perceived by party leadership as a threat to regime durability rather than a necessary accompaniment to economic reform.

5.2 Where enforcement overreached and what it cost

Acknowledging the PRC threat documented in Part 4 is analytically necessary. Acknowledging where the U.S. response was disproportionate, discriminatory, or counterproductive is equally

necessary. What follows identifies four domains in which U.S. enforcement appears to have substituted breadth for precision, with significant legal, institutional, and strategic costs.

The China Initiative (the precise institutional failure that Section 6.1's conduct-based enforcement principle addresses): legitimate counterintelligence concern, flawed and at times discriminatory execution. Attorney General Jeff Sessions launched the China Initiative on November 1, 2018[72]. MIT Technology Review's investigation identified 77 known cases involving more than 150 defendants (APA Justice analysis tracked 162 individuals)[73]. Only 25% involved Economic Espionage Act violations; 30% involved grant or visa fraud. The initiative produced a series of high-profile prosecutorial failures that raised serious questions about investigative methodology, evidentiary discipline, and the risks of overbroad suspicion in academic settings:

Gang Chen (MIT), arrested January 2021 — charges dropped January 2022 after prosecutors conceded they could no longer meet the burden of proof. Five of seven alleged Chinese collaborations did not exist. Over 200 MIT faculty signed a letter declaring "We are all Gang Chen."

Anming Hu (University of Tennessee), arrested February 2020 — acquitted September 2021 after a mistrial and the judge's ruling that no rational jury could find the evidence sufficient. FBI Agent Kujtim Sadiku admitted he did not believe Hu was a spy yet continued surveillance for approximately 21 months (inferred from case timeline: investigation initiated ~May 2018, arrest February 2020).

Xiaoxing Xi[76] (Temple University), arrested May 2015 at dawn by FBI agents with guns drawn — charges dropped four months later when scientists confirmed Xi had shared a completely different, unrestricted device. The FBI had not consulted subject-matter experts.

Feng "Franklin" Tao (University of Kansas), first academic formally charged under the China Initiative — convictions overturned by the 10th Circuit on July 11, 2024. The investigation had been triggered by a visiting scholar who threatened to report Tao as a spy unless paid $300,000 (per trial record and 10th Circuit appellate filings).

AAG Matthew Olsen terminated the Initiative on February 23, 2022, stating that it fueled a narrative of intolerance and bias, and that this erosion of trust can impair national security by alienating the communities the PRC often targets as victims.

The collateral damage was substantial. NIH identified approximately 400 researchers[78] of possible concern, investigated 246 — 81% of whom were Asian. Of those investigated, 103 lost their jobs. A 2023 PNAS study found departures of U.S.-based, China-born scientists increased by 75% following the China Initiative, with 67% of departing scientists moving to China by 2021. An Asian American Scholar Forum survey found 72% of Chinese-American researchers did not feel safe, and 45% were avoiding federal grant applications. The JASON report (December 2019)[80] recommended handling disclosure violations within research integrity frameworks rather than criminal prosecution, finding that what intelligence agencies interpreted as theft "actually appears to be the collegial sharing of academic work" in some cases.

The analytical distinction is clear. Cases like Xu Yanjun and Charles Lieber represent genuine counterintelligence threats. Cases like Gang Chen, Anming Hu, and Xiaoxing Xi represent

flawed implementation — poor investigative work, failure to consult experts, and a structural incentive to target anyone with connections to China.

Overbroad tariffs functioned as consumer taxes. Section 301 tariffs eventually covered approximately $370–550 billion in Chinese imports. The first two lists ($50 billion) targeted industrial and strategic goods with a defensible policy rationale. Lists 3 and 4A ($320 billion) extended to consumer goods where they functioned primarily as regressive consumer taxes. The New York Federal Reserve (Amiti, Redding, and Weinstein, 2019) found complete passthrough of tariffs to domestic import prices — an estimated annual cost of $831 per household[81]. The Federal Reserve Board found that manufacturing industries exposed to tariffs experienced relative reductions in employment, with approximately 175,000 net manufacturing jobs lost[90] (gross negative effect of ~230,000 through input costs, partially offset by ~40,000 jobs gained through import protection). CBO's February 2026 analysis found 95% of tariff costs[82] were borne by U.S. firms and consumers (this estimate covers the tariff regime as of early 2026, including both the original Section 301 tariffs and expanded tariffs; earlier NY Fed studies found comparable passthrough for the original tariffs alone). The overall U.S. goods trade deficit increased as imports shifted to Vietnam, Mexico, and other intermediaries.

Export controls accelerated the investment they sought to prevent. BIS's October 2022 semiconductor controls represented what Gregory Allen (CSIS) called a major reversal of over 25 years of trade and technology policy. The paradox materialized within a year: SMIC produced 7nm chips by August 2023 without EUV access. The PRC responded with massive investment acceleration — Big Fund Phase III ($47.5 billion, May 2024)[37]. China spent $41 billion on wafer fab equipment in 2024, approximately 40% of all global purchases. CSIS assessed in 2025 that U.S. and allied export controls are inadvertently adding impetus to the Chinese government's long-standing goal of localizing semiconductor supply. National Security Advisor Sullivan articulated the governing principle as "small yard, high fence" — but in practice, the yard expanded significantly across four rounds of controls.

Treatment of Chinese-American scientists and researchers. The NIH investigation sweep, the China Initiative prosecutions, and the broader climate of suspicion produced measurable talent flight. The distinction between defending against genuine PRC-directed acquisition efforts and subjecting researchers to investigation based on ethnicity or national origin is not merely a civil-liberties concern — it is a strategic concern, because the scientists driven from U.S. institutions by discriminatory enforcement are precisely the human capital the United States needs to maintain technological leadership.

5.3 What honest assessment requires — Integrating legitimate security concerns with enforcement design

The analytical framework of this paper produces two conclusions that U.S. policy has historically treated as contradictory but which are simultaneously true.

The United States has legitimate security interests that PRC conduct threatens. The intelligence operations documented in Section 4.1 — including the aggregate IP theft estimated at $225–600 billion annually — constitute a structural economic threat. The cyber pre-positioning documented in Section 4.2 represents preparation for wartime disruption of civilian infrastructure. The military modernization documented in Section 4.3 is designed to dissuade or

defeat U.S. defense of allies. The economic coercion documented in Section 4.4 targets democratic allies for exercising sovereign policy choices. The fentanyl precursor supply documented in Section 4.5 contributes to over 70,000 American deaths annually. The forced labor and transnational repression documented in Section 4.5 constitute human rights violations with direct implications for U.S. law (UFLPA) and the security of persons on U.S. soil. These are real threats requiring real enforcement.

The PRC has legitimate development interests that U.S. policy sometimes constrains unnecessarily. China's pursuit of economic growth and technological capability is not illegitimate. Overbroad tariffs that tax American consumers without strategic benefit, export controls whose primary long-term effect is to accelerate indigenous substitution, and criminal prosecutions of scientists for administrative disclosure errors do not advance U.S. security — they degrade it.

Both are true simultaneously. Enforcement that fails to acknowledge this produces policy that is either too permissive (the engagement era) or too blunt (the China Initiative, overbroad tariffs, expanding export controls). The PRC threat is institutional, not civilizational — and enforcement designed around that distinction produces better security outcomes, fewer civil-liberties violations, and more durable policy.

Connection to enforcement architecture. The synthesis above is not an academic exercise. It is the analytic foundation for the enforcement design principles developed in Part 6. If the United States calibrates enforcement without understanding that sovereignty-linked domains produce maximum PRC resistance while commercial domains remain amenable to cost-benefit pressure (Section 6.1), enforcement intensity will be misallocated. If analysts do not recognize that the PRC processes sanctions simultaneously as practical constraints and as evidence confirming the Century of Humiliation narrative (Section 6.2, Prediction 2), they will underestimate the adaptation cycle that erodes coercive effectiveness. And if policymakers do not distinguish between Hypothesis A (purely defensive), Hypothesis B (revisionist), and Hypothesis C (mixed) — the assessment this paper supports at MODERATE CONFIDENCE (Section 6.3) — they will design enforcement for an adversary that does not exist. The failures documented in Part 5 are the empirical record of what happens when enforcement is designed without this integration.

PART 6 — Implications for Enforcement Architecture

The preceding analysis is designed to improve the enforcement architecture developed across the WP-2026 series — specifically STRAT-NSCC-01, UNIFIED-01, CTF-01, CPF-02, and ARCH-03 — by introducing a variable those documents handle implicitly: the ideological and strategic-cultural framework within which PRC decision-makers process, adapt to, and exploit U.S. enforcement actions.

6.1 How ideological analysis concretely improves enforcement design

The Century of Humiliation frame predicts which enforcement actions generate narrative backlash. STRAT-NSCC-01 proposes a financial deterrence architecture (Action 3.4) targeting PRC financial institutions that facilitate sanctions evasion. The ideological analysis predicts that broad-based financial restrictions targeting Chinese banking as a sector would be processed as civilizational containment and would strengthen, not weaken, the CCP's domestic position. Conduct-based targeting of specific institutions for documented sanctions violations is processable within the PRC system as enforcement against specific misconduct.

UNIFIED-01's integrated enforcement framework operates across CTF-01, CPF-02, and ARCH-03. The ideological analysis generates a design principle applicable across all three, derived from the analysis presented in this paper: target the conduct, not the country; target the entity, not the ethnicity; target the network, not the narrative. The China Initiative's failure (Section 5.2) provides empirical evidence of what occurs when this conduct-based distinction is not maintained: prosecutorial overreach, chilled academic collaboration, and enforcement actions that strengthened rather than weakened the adversary's domestic narrative.

Understanding the CCP legitimacy model identifies where economic pressure creates genuine political pressure versus where it reinforces regime narratives. The analysis indicates that sanctions architectures may be more effective when they prioritize actions that make the CCP's own institutional choices costly to its economic base, rather than actions that impose costs on the Chinese economy broadly. The former creates internal pressure; the latter creates external solidarity.

Understanding party-state-military structure identifies which entities are state-directed versus independently motivated. CPF-02's counter-proliferation framework should weight entity designations according to evidentiary tiers of state direction: documented party-committee control (highest confidence), institutional affiliation with CMF-designated entities (moderate confidence), and inferred state connection through behavioral patterns (lower confidence, requiring additional corroboration).

Understanding adversary adaptation patterns generates enforcement refresh requirements. The analysis suggests that enforcement mechanisms incorporating explicit decay assumptions and refresh cycles are likely to be more effective than static designs when applied to an adaptive adversary. The semiconductor case demonstrates that controls imposed in October 2022 were partially circumvented within 12 months and substantially circumvented within 36 months. Every enforcement action should include an explicit shelf-life estimate and a planned recalibration cycle.

Friction caveat. These design implications are probabilistic rather than deterministic. PRC responses to enforcement actions are mediated by bureaucratic incentives, leadership signaling, and external conditions that may produce variation not captured by the ideological model alone.

6.2 What the ideology predicts about enforcement effectiveness

The following predictions are analytic judgments derived from observed patterns and available reporting. They are probabilistic assessments, not deterministic forecasts, and are subject to revision as new evidence emerges.

Prediction 1: Sanctions pressure is unlikely to change PRC behavior on sovereignty-linked issues. Taiwan, the South China Sea, Xinjiang, Tibet, and Hong Kong are classified within the CCP's framework as "core interests" — regime-survival issues where loss aversion dominates. It is unlikely that economic sanctions alone would induce the PRC to alter its position on these issues. These are regime-legitimacy commitments from which retreat would constitute existential political failure.

Falsification condition: Sustained PRC capitulation on a sovereignty-linked issue in response to economic pressure alone, without offsetting gains on a different sovereignty-linked issue.

Prediction 2: Sanctions pressure can change PRC behavior on non-sovereignty-linked issues — and has. Fentanyl precursor control, DPRK sanctions enforcement, and counterterrorism cooperation are areas where the CCP has demonstrated willingness to adjust behavior in response to pressure. The PRC's 2019 fentanyl scheduling and periodic DPRK sanctions enforcement demonstrate that the party-state's cost-benefit calculus on non-sovereignty issues is more conventional. CTF-01's enforcement framework operates in this space and should expect greater compliance traction.

Falsification condition: PRC refusal to cooperate on any non-sovereignty-linked enforcement issue despite significant and sustained economic incentives.

Prediction 3: Export controls buy time but do not create permanent advantage. The autarky impulse is ideologically driven and will persist regardless of U.S. policy. Export controls are likely to delay PRC achievement of leading-edge capability by a finite but uncertain interval, plausibly on the order of several years under current trajectories. This does not mean controls are useless — a multi-year delay has genuine strategic value. It means controls must be understood as time-buying instruments and designed accordingly.

Falsification condition: PRC semiconductor capability plateauing permanently below leading-edge despite sustained investment, indicating controls can create enduring rather than temporary advantage.

Prediction 4: Financial deterrence must be calibrated to asymmetric risk tolerance. PRC risk tolerance for financial costs is asymmetric by domain: high tolerance on sovereignty-linked issues, but conventional sensitivity on commercial and non-sovereignty issues. Financial deterrence calibrated to the commercial domain — e.g., threatening to cut PRC banks off from dollar clearing for documented sanctions violations — can change institutional behavior. The same mechanism targeted at sovereignty-linked behavior will be absorbed as a cost of regime legitimacy.

Falsification condition: PRC financial institutions defecting from party-state policy on a sovereignty-linked issue specifically in response to U.S. financial deterrence.

Prediction 5: Conduct-based enforcement is less likely to generate CCP domestic mobilization than broad, country-level measures. Enforcement actions that can be framed as anti-Chinese rather than anti-CCP feed the Century of Humiliation narrative. On current evidence, precisely targeted, conduct-based enforcement is less likely to generate domestic mobilization, although this remains insufficiently tested.

Falsification condition: Evidence that precisely targeted, conduct-based enforcement generates equivalent or greater CCP domestic mobilization than broad, country-specific measures.

6.3 Competing hypotheses: defensive, revisionist, or mixed

The analytical standard governing this paper — ICD 203 — requires competing hypotheses where evidence is mixed.

Hypothesis A: PRC behavior is primarily defensive. PRC strategic conduct is driven by genuine security concerns and historical grievance. Military modernization and intelligence operations are defensive responses to perceived encirclement. Taiwan is an unfinished civil war sovereignty issue.

Evidence supporting A: The Century of Humiliation narrative is not fabricated. PRC territorial claims predate CCP rule. Fravel shows China offered concessions in 17 of 23 territorial disputes through 2005 and uses force from perceived weakness. The ODNI characterizes the PRC as more cautious than Russia, Iran, and North Korea. PRC defense spending as a percentage of GDP (~1.7%) is significantly lower than the U.S. (~3.4%). The PRC has not fought a war since 1979.

Implication if A is correct: Engagement and reassurance would reduce threat more effectively than enforcement and deterrence.

Hypothesis B: PRC behavior is primarily revisionist. PRC strategic conduct is driven by institutional imperatives to displace U.S. primacy. Intelligence and cyber operations are offensive instruments of grand strategy.

Evidence supporting B: Doshi's internal party documents demonstrate conscious displacement strategies. Xi's "great changes unseen in a century" encodes an assessment of U.S. decline. The CMPR 2024 states PRC strategy aims to revise the international order. Nuclear force expansion from ~200 to projected 1,000+ warheads is difficult to explain within a purely defensive framework. Volt Typhoon pre-positioning in civilian infrastructure goes beyond deterrence.

Implication if B is correct: Deterrence and enforcement are necessary and should be intensified.

Hypothesis C: PRC behavior is mixed — defensive on some issues, revisionist on others, with the balance shifting based on leadership assessment of U.S. resolve and capability. On sovereignty-linked issues, behavior is primarily defensive. On international order issues,

behavior is primarily revisionist. On commercial and economic issues, behavior is mixed and contingent.

Evidence supporting C: The PRC simultaneously cooperates on some enforcement issues (fentanyl, periodic DPRK sanctions) and resists on others (Taiwan, South China Sea), which is inconsistent with purely defensive or revisionist models. The ODNI ATAs describe both deep suspicion and desire for stable economic relations. Fravel's territorial pragmatism coexists with militarized assertiveness on non-negotiable issues.

The strongest version of Hypothesis C specifies the sorting mechanism: CCP ideology determines which issues are sovereignty-linked (defensive response) and which are order-linked (revisionist response). The Century of Humiliation frame makes territorial integrity issues existential. The great rejuvenation frame makes international order revision aspirational but opportunistic.

Assessment. The available evidence is most consistent with Hypothesis C, although elements of Hypotheses A and B remain operative across different issue domains. **MODERATE CONFIDENCE.** This confidence level reflects that the assessment is supported by multiple independent lines of evidence, but significant uncertainty remains due to limited visibility into internal PRC decision-making.

Hypothesis A cannot be dismissed because the defensive elements of PRC behavior are genuine, not performative. Hypothesis B cannot be dismissed because the revisionist elements — internal party documents, nuclear expansion, Volt Typhoon — are equally genuine.

Implication for enforcement architecture. Hypothesis C indicates that enforcement design should be calibrated by issue domain. Sovereignty-linked enforcement is likely to encounter maximum resistance and generate maximum narrative backlash. Order-linked enforcement is likely to encounter strategic adaptation but less existential resistance. Commercial enforcement is more likely to encounter conventional cost-benefit resistance that remains amenable to economic incentives. The WP-2026 enforcement architecture should therefore sort its mechanisms explicitly across these three domains.

PART 7 — Adversarial Interpretation and Limitations

7.1 What would invalidate this analysis

A fundamental shift in CCP governing ideology. If a post-Xi leadership transition produces a CCP that abandons the great rejuvenation framework, the predictive framework of this paper would require fundamental revision. This is unlikely in the near term but not impossible.

Sustained PRC cooperation on issues this analysis predicts it will resist. If the PRC cooperates meaningfully on sovereignty-linked issues in response to economic pressure alone — ceasing South China Sea militarization or accepting formal Taiwan independence in exchange for economic concessions — Hypothesis C would be invalidated.

Evidence that PRC strategic culture is less coherent than presented. This paper models PRC decision-making as sufficiently influenced by ideological and institutional factors to produce observable patterns, while recognizing that coherence may be partial rather than complete. If evidence emerged that decision-making is governed primarily by personal patronage networks or bureaucratic politics rather than strategic-cultural frameworks, the paper's predictive framework would be weakened.

Evidence that PRC adaptation to enforcement is slower than modeled. If SMIC's semiconductor progress stalls at current nodes, if export controls prove more durable than the paper predicts, the claims about ideologically driven adaptation speed would be overstated. First empirical test: whether SMIC achieves volume production at 3nm-equivalent or below by 2028.

Evidence that the Century of Humiliation narrative has diminishing domestic resonance. If younger, internationally connected Chinese populations prove less susceptible to the victimhood narrative than assumed, enforcement actions predicted to mobilize domestic support for the CCP might instead generate domestic pressure against the regime.

Evidence that the party-civilization distinction is less separable than modeled. The paper's entire analytical architecture rests on the mandatory distinction between CCP institutional conduct and Chinese civilizational identity. If the party has successfully fused itself with civilizational identity to the point where targeting CCP conduct is experienced by the Chinese population as targeting their civilization, then Prediction 5 fails and the enforcement design principle in Section 6.1 does not work as described. This is the hardest invalidation condition because it challenges the paper's foundational commitment, which is exactly why it must be stated. The possibility that the CCP's civilizational appropriation (documented in Section 1.2) has succeeded — that the party-civilization merger is not merely rhetorical but cognitively real for a substantial portion of the population — would require fundamental revision of the paper's enforcement logic.

7.2 Scope limitations

These are not caveats added for academic propriety. They are constraints on what the analysis can and cannot know.

This analysis is conducted from a policy and enforcement perspective rather than an area-studies or language-specialist perspective. The author is not a sinologist, not a China specialist, and not a Mandarin-fluent analyst. The author cannot read PRC primary sources in original Mandarin and relies on official English translations and scholarly translations. Translation artifacts are invisible to the author.

This analysis relies exclusively on open-source materials. No classified intelligence informs this paper. Internal CCP deliberations on strategy, threat perception, and enforcement response are not accessible. What appears as ideological coherence in official statements may mask internal disagreement, bureaucratic competition, or strategic deception that classified reporting would reveal.

PRC decision-making opacity means all assessments of internal deliberation are inferred. When the paper states that the CCP processes sanctions through the Century of Humiliation frame, this is an inference from regime rhetoric and behavioral patterns, not a directly observed cognitive process. The inference may be wrong. The regime may invoke the narrative instrumentally while making decisions on entirely different grounds.

The analysis may underweight factional dynamics within CCP leadership. Xi's personalist consolidation has compressed but not eliminated factional politics. The 2023–2024 purges of Qin Gang, Li Shangfu, and Rocket Force leadership suggest internal dynamics invisible from open sources.

The paper draws heavily on a small number of foundational academic works. Johnston (*Cultural Realism*), Doshi (*The Long Game*), Economy (*The Third Revolution*), and Wang (*Never Forget National Humiliation*) are each subject to scholarly critique. Doshi's displacement narrative has been criticized for attributing excessive strategic coherence. The paper's strategic periodization relies substantially on Doshi's interpretive framework of blunting, building, and expansion. If that framework overstates coherence or misidentifies phase transitions, the paper's account of PRC long-horizon strategic behavior would require revision. Over-reliance on any single theorist produces analytical blind spots.

The "silent liberal majority" complicates assumptions about domestic mobilization. Pan and Xu's survey data[84] suggests more liberal, less nationalistic views among educated, urban Chinese than official discourse implies. If this population is politically significant, the paper may overestimate the CCP's ability to convert enforcement pressure into domestic solidarity.

Temporal limitations. This paper was drafted in April 2026. Assessments about SMIC's capability trajectory, nuclear expansion rates, and enforcement effectiveness will degrade in accuracy over 12–24 months.

The paper's own framing may contain analytical biases the author cannot identify. An American policy researcher assessing PRC strategic culture through Western analytical frameworks inevitably imports assumptions about rationality and state behavior that may not map accurately. The parabellum/accommodationist and defensive/revisionist debates are Western categories imposed on Chinese strategic thought. This is a necessary analytical simplification, but it is a simplification.

Appendix A — Claims Requiring Additional Validation or Carrying Elevated Uncertainty

1. **Shelf-life estimate for export control measures (Section 6.2, Prediction 3).** Inferred from the SMIC case and not a statistically derived figure. Different technology domains will have different decay rates. The estimate may underestimate durability for technologies where indigenous substitution is harder (e.g., EUV lithography).

2. **Claim that conduct-based enforcement generates less CCP domestic mobilization than country-specific measures (Section 6.2, Prediction 5).** Analytically intuitive but not empirically tested. The PRC propaganda apparatus may frame any enforcement as anti-Chinese regardless of targeting precision.

3. **Assessment that Hypothesis C warrants MODERATE CONFIDENCE (Section 6.3).** An analytic judgment, not a statistical measure. An alternative assessment could reasonably assign HIGH CONFIDENCE based on evidence volume or LOW CONFIDENCE based on PRC decision-making opacity.

4. **Claim that a succession crisis following Xi could produce ideological reorientation within 3–5 years (Section 7.1).** Speculative. Xi has eliminated the grooming-successor mechanism that facilitated previous transitions.

5. **Assumption that the Century of Humiliation frame has increasing domestic resonance (Sections 6.1, 6.2).** Survey evidence cannot distinguish genuine ideological commitment from strategic response to survey conditions in an authoritarian context.

6. **Claim that PRC risk tolerance on sovereignty issues exceeds what Western models predict (Section 6.2, Prediction 4).** Not tested under conditions of severe economic stress. The PRC has never faced comprehensive sanctions equivalent to the Russia post-2022 regime.

7. **Treatment of the CCP as a substantially unified actor under Xi (Section 7.2).** A necessary analytical simplification that is almost certainly wrong in detail.

8. **Fentanyl precursor enforcement gap as reflecting CCP priorities rather than incapacity (Section 4.5).** Supported by the contrast between domestic drug enforcement and export-facing leniency, but the causal inference — that this reflects deliberate policy choice — is an assessment, not a proven fact.

9. **IP theft cost estimates of $225–600 billion annually (Section 4.1/4.5).** The IP Commission's methodology is contested. The range is extremely wide. Even the lower bound represents a significant economic impact, but the figures should be treated as order-of-magnitude estimates.

Draft produced April 11, 2026. Unified editorial hardening pass applied. All editorial replacement language from three hostile reviews incorporated. Part 4 expanded with fentanyl, forced labor, transnational repression, and IP theft content. Part 4→5 bridging paragraph added. BLUF revised to Hypothesis C framing. Section 7.1 invalidation condition on party-civilization distinction added. Source-integrity audit complete (92 endnotes). CI Assessment pending.

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